

Saponaria officinalis (Caryophyllaceae)

Soapwort

Description Perennial growing to a height of 3 ft (1 m). Soapwort has lance-shaped leaves and clusters of delicate pink 5-petaled tubular flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to temperate regions of Europe, Asia, and North America, soapwort thrives in open woodland areas and on railroad embankments. It has been widely cultivated as a garden plant. The herb is gathered while in flower in summer; the root is unearthed in autumn.

Parts Used Root, aerial parts.

Constituents All parts of soapwort contain saponins (around 5%), resin, and a small quantity of volatile oil.



Soapwort is an expectorant plant used to relieve bronchitis and coughs.

History & Folklore Soapwort has mostly been used as a substitute for soap, especially in washing clothes. Boerhaave (1668–1738), a Dutch physician, recommended soapwort as a treatment for jaundice.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Soapwort's main internal use is as an expectorant. Its strongly irritant action within the gut is thought to stimulate the cough reflex and increase the production of a more fluid mucus within the respiratory passages. Consequently, the plant is prescribed for bronchitis, coughs, and some cases of asthma. Soapwort may be taken for other problems, including rheumatic

and arthritic pain. A decoction of the root, and, to a lesser extent, an infusion of the aerial parts of the herb, make soothing washes for eczema and other itchy skin conditions.

⚠ **Cautions** Soapwort is a potentially toxic herb. Take internally only under professional supervision.

Sargassum fusiforme (Sargassaceae)

Hai Zao, Hijiki

Description Brown seaweed (alga) with long thin fronds.

Habitat & Cultivation *Hai zao* is found along the coastlines of China and Japan, where it is often seen floating in large masses. It is gathered throughout the year.

Part Used Whole plant.

Constituents *Hai zao* contains polysaccharides, alginic acid, and significant levels of potassium and iodine.

History & Folklore Wang Tao, an 8th-century Chinese physician, recommended *hai zao* for goiter (an enlargement of the thyroid gland due to iodine deficiency). *Hai zao* is eaten as a vegetable in Chinese and Japanese cuisine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Hai zao* is used in a similar way to its European counterpart, the seaweed bladderwrack, or kelp (*Fucus vesiculosus*, p. 213). In Chinese medicine, it is given principally to treat thyroid problems caused by low iodine levels within the body. The herb also helps to combat other thyroid conditions that produce enlargement of the gland, for example Hashimoto's thyroiditis. *Hai zao* is prescribed to treat cases of scrofula (enlargement of the lymph glands in the neck due to tubercular infection) and edema (fluid retention).

Research Chinese research indicates that *hai zao* has antifungal and immunomodulating activity.

Related Species In Chinese medicine, *S. fusiforme* is used interchangeably with *S. pallidum*.

⚠ **Caution** Do not take *hai zao* for thyroid problems without professional supervision.

Satureja montana (Lamiaceae)

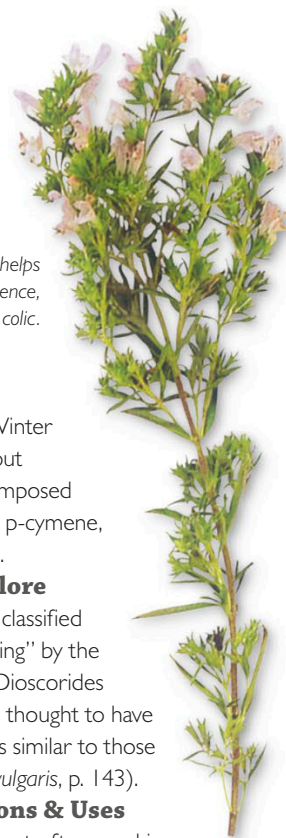
Winter Savory

Description Semi-evergreen aromatic herb growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has lance-shaped leaves and white-pink flowers appearing in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe, winter savory thrives in sunny, well-drained sites. It is commonly cultivated as a garden herb. The flowering tops are collected in summer.

Parts Used Flowering tops, essential oil.

Winter savory helps to alleviate flatulence, indigestion, and colic.



Constituents Winter savory contains about 1.6% volatile oil, composed mainly of carvacrol, p-cymene, linalool, and thymol.

History & Folklore

Winter savory was classified as "heating and drying" by the classical physicians Dioscorides and Galen, and was thought to have therapeutic benefits similar to those of thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143).

Medicinal Actions & Uses

Winter savory is most often used in cooking, but it also has marked medicinal benefits. It settles gas and stimulates digestion, helping to alleviate flatulence and colic. It is warming and has been taken for chest infections and bronchitis. The essential oil is strongly antibacterial and may be used to treat candidiasis and other fungal conditions.

Related Species Summer savory (*S. hortensis*) is a similar herb that has a milder essential oil. Calamint (*Calamintha ascendens*, p. 181) is another close relative.

Cautions Do not take the essential oil internally without professional supervision. Do not take winter savory during pregnancy.

Saussurea lappa syn. *S. costus* (Asteraceae)

Kuth

Description Upright perennial herb growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has heart-shaped leaves and blue-black flowerheads.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Indian subcontinent, kuth is most commonly found in mountainous areas of Kashmir. The root is gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Root, essential oil.

Constituents Kuth contains a volatile oil (consisting of terpenes, sesquiterpenes, and apotaxene), an alkaloid (saussarine), and a resin. Saussarine depresses the parasympathetic nervous system.